At last, one clear morning, after a routine handful of circuits over the airfield, we landed softly and Booley jumped out as if the Firefly were on fire.

What's the matter?

It's time, Lieutenant Wales.

Time?

For you to solo.

Oh. OK.

Up I went. (After first making sure my parachute was strapped on.) I did one or two circuits round the airfield, talking to myself all the while: *Full power. Keep the wheel on the white line. Pull up…slowly! Dip the nose. Don't stall! Turn in the climb. Level off. OK, now you're downwind. Radio the tower. Check your ground markers.*

Pre-landing checks.

Reduce power!

Start to descend in the turn.

There you go, steady now.

Roll out there, line up, line it up.

Three-degree flight path, get the nose on the piano keys.

Request clearance to land.

Point the aircraft where you want it to land…

I made an uneventful one-bounce landing and taxied off the runway. To the average person it would've looked like the most mundane flight in the history of aviation. To me it was one of the most wonderful moments of my life.

Was I a pilot now? Hardly. But I was on my way.

I jumped out, marched up to Booley. My God, I wanted to high-five him, take him out for drinks, but it was out of the question.

The one thing I absolutely didn't want to do was say goodbye to him, but that was what needed to happen next. Now that I'd soloed, I needed to embark on the next phase of my training.

As Booley was so fond of saying, it was time.